

blame, as you're under the pump with such an emotional pursuit.

Do a dry run

Stephen Smith is a former Opera Australia tenor turned sales agent and auctioneer, whose rich vocals now command a different kind of audience's attention. He says to never make the auction you will bid at the first you've ever attended. Smith, of agency Marshall White, advises attending as many other auctions as you can in the lead-up to your day of reckoning, to acclimatise to the tension, observe the changes in pace, see auctioneers in action and make sense of bidders' body language. And if you have done prep work – by way of market research – you will know how far you can be tested, and bid confidently from the outset to the crescendo.

Smith says:

It is a game of psychology, and if you can be the one who has tested themselves before you get there, you can knock others off before they stretch to their absolute most. If you can go to 20 or 30 auctions over a number of weeks, you will get a true feel for the process. It is easy to get spooked when the auctioneer calls 'First, second and third and final call', and not to know there is a way to go. Learn those lessons.

Send in a surrogate

Auctioneer Stuart Benson, the director of Benson Auctions, says that if you're uncomfortable with the auction process and think that, by the end, 'you will have no fingernails left and will be on dialysis because something in you will have shut down', you can sign over the authority for a proxy to bid and buy on your behalf.

You don't have to be the one bidding in order to sign the sale contract, so assign a trusted ally – anyone who can perform with ruthless detachment – to bid for you. Arm them with your budget limit and stand back, fingers crossed. Real estate agents can be hired, for a fee, to bid for you. A buyers' advocate will help you find the home, at a cost, but if you have done that part yourself and just require a gun bidder, approach a local real estate agency. You can tell them your budget and instruct them at what level to bid to. (A buyers' advocate can assist you in two ways: finding the property and